A Safe Schools Guide

A Christian's Guide to Corporal Punishment

The rod, the fruit, and the school board

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EarthPilot

earthpilot.org/kids

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Every study and church position cited is a verified claim in the Safe Schools facts registry, earthpilot.org/kids/resources/, with its primary source.

EarthPilot, Kansas City, Missouri

Who this is for

Pastors, Sunday school teachers, church members, and the believer who sits on a school board in one of the seventeen states where a public school employee may still paddle a child.

Every verse is quoted from the King James Bible and was checked against the text. Every figure is tied to a verified source in the Safe Schools facts registry at earthpilot.org/kids/resources/, and the source is named at the foot of its page.

If you have three minutes and nothing else, read aloud the page at the end that was written for it.

Facts registry: law-states-permitting-count

THE BIBLE SAYS WHAT IT SAYS.
IT DOES. IT ALSO SAYS HOW TO JUDGE WHAT WE DO WITH IT.

Why a minister is writing this

I was an ordained minister in another life. I came to school corporal punishment by accident, around 2011, when someone sent me the federal count of children paddled in public schools. In those years it was more than a hundred thousand children a year. The last count is under twenty thousand.

The conversation that mattered most was never the one about the research. It was the one in a church fellowship hall, with a superintendent who told me, gently, that the Bible says what it says. He was right that it says it. I think the Bible also tells us how to judge what we do with it.

Facts registry: crdc-national-trend-2013-to-2022; crdc-national-total-2023-24-computed

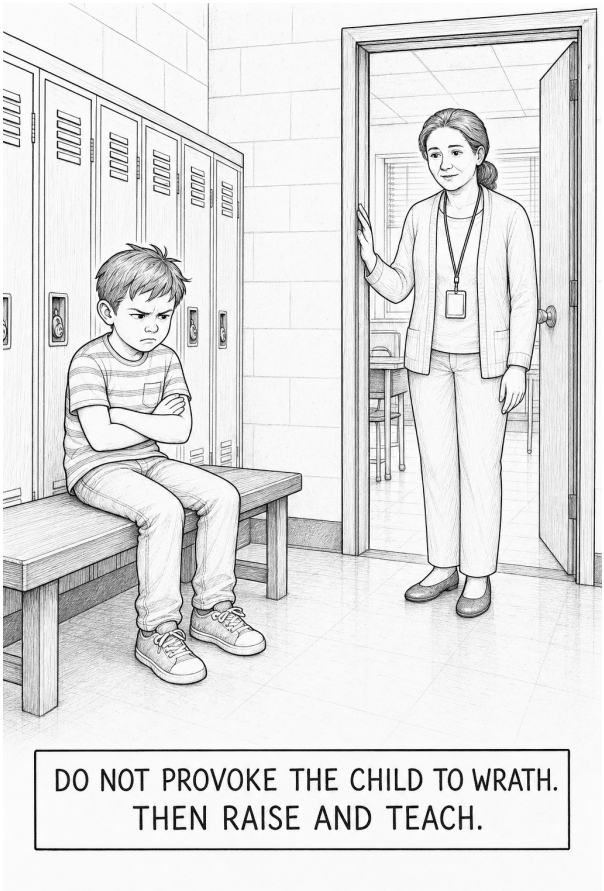
A DISCIPLE IS A LEARNER.

Teaching them to observe all things

Matthew 28:19-20; Proverbs 22:6

In English, discipline and disciple are the same root; the Latin behind both means a pupil, a learner. When the risen Christ sends the eleven out, the King James renders his command as teaching. Discipline, in the sense the Bible cares about, is what makes a learner.

Train up a child in the way he should go. Train: the teacher's word. The question for any method of discipline is whether the child learns.

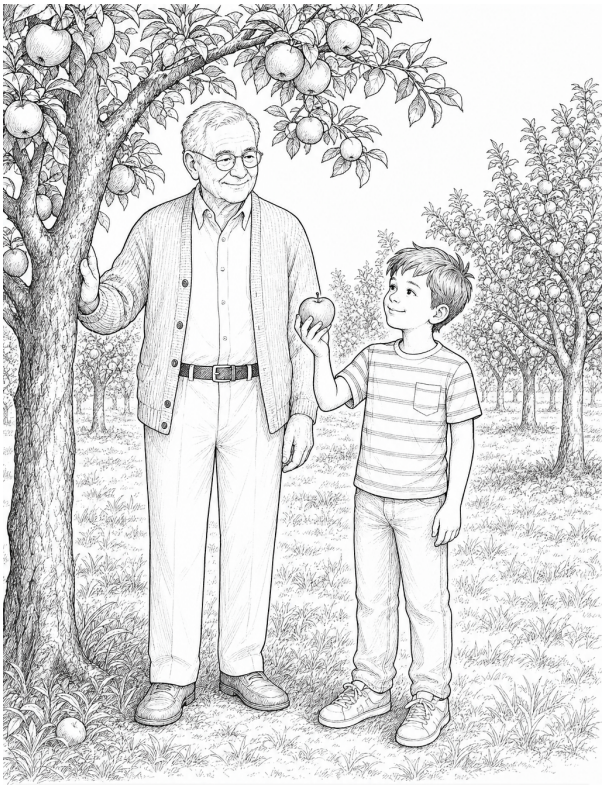

DO NOT PROVOKE THE CHILD TO WRATH.
THEN RAISE AND TEACH.

Provoke not your children to wrath

Ephesians 6:4

Paul says it to fathers with a warning on both sides: provoke not your children to wrath, but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord. Nurture is raising. Admonition is instruction and warning.

The verse has a prohibition in front of its command. Do not provoke the child to wrath. Then raise and teach. A method that produces an angry child has failed the first half of the verse before we get to the second.



JUDGE IT BY WHAT IT YIELDS AFTERWARD.

Afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness

Hebrews 12:11

The writer to the Hebrews does not pretend that discipline feels good. "No chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous." Then he tells us how to judge it: by what it yields afterward.

Not by whether it hurt. Not by whether the child was quiet for the rest of the afternoon. Not by whether it was done in love. By the fruit, later, in the person who was exercised by it. The whole of this little book rests on that verse.

I AM QUOTING ALL OF THEM. I DO NOT WANT TO BE ACCUSED OF HIDING ONE.

He that spareth his rod hateth his son

Proverbs 13:24, 22:15, 23:13-14, 29:15, 19:18

These are the verses people have in mind when they say the Bible permits paddling, and every one of them is listed at the back, because I do not want to be accused of hiding one. They say a rod. They say beat. They say a father who loves his son corrects him early.

I am not going to tell you they mean something other than what they say. Christian scholars differ about them, and I am not going to settle that here. I do not need to, for two reasons.

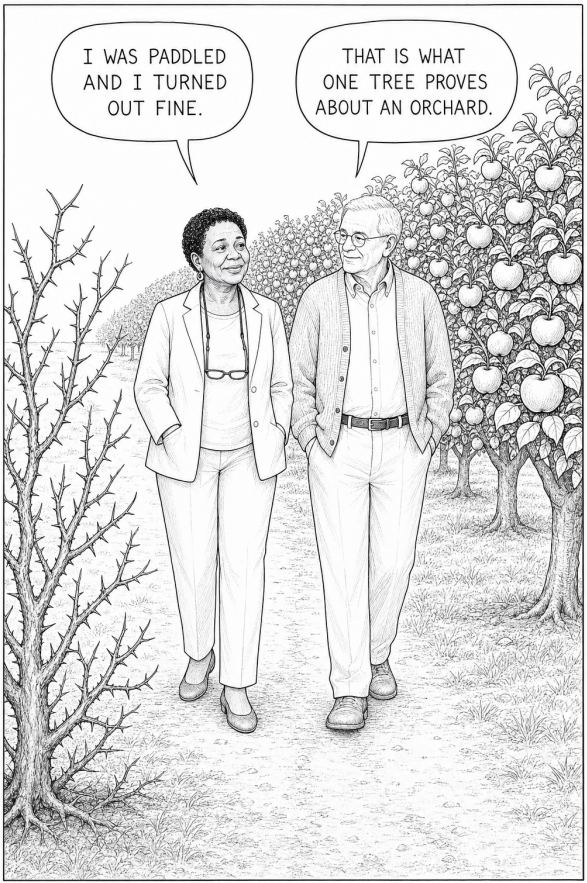
NOT ONE OF THOSE VERSES IS ADDRESSED TO A SCHOOL.

His son. Thy son.

Not one of them is addressed to a school

First: every one of those verses is addressed to a parent about that parent's own child. Not one is addressed to a school, a magistrate, a government, or an employee of the state holding someone else's child.

The question before a school board is not whether the Bible permits a father to correct his son. It is whether a public employee may strike a child who is not his, with a wooden paddle, as a matter of district policy. Proverbs does not speak to that.


I WAS PADDLED AND I TURNED OUT FINE.
THAT IS WHAT ONE TREE PROVES ABOUT AN ORCHARD.

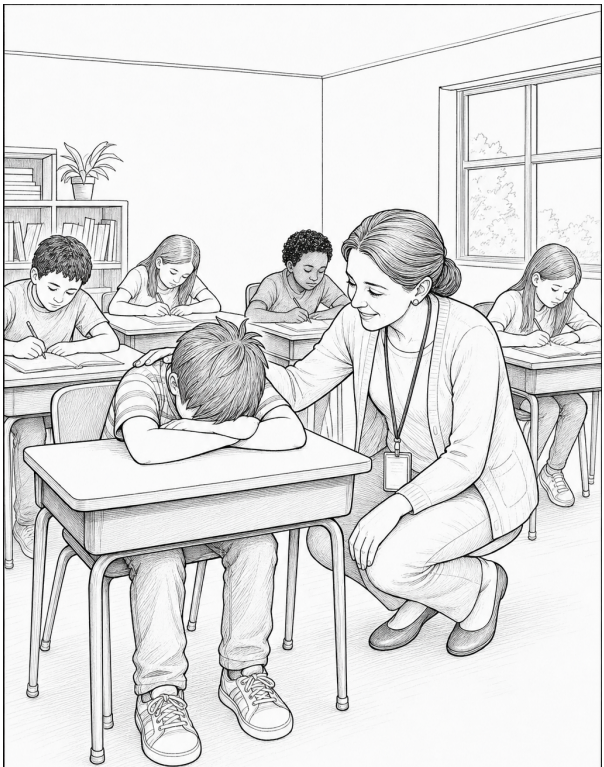
Ye shall know them by their fruits

Matthew 7:16

Second: scripture tells us how to judge any discipline, and it does not say judge it by whether it is mentioned in Proverbs. It says judge it by what it yields. Many people my age were paddled in school and will tell you they turned out fine, which proves what one tree proves about an orchard.

For the orchard we have the research. In 2016 two researchers gathered every usable study of spanking: seventy-five studies, more than one hundred and sixty thousand children, seventeen outcomes measured. Thirteen of the seventeen were worse for the children who were hit. Not one was better.

Facts registry: study-gershoff-grogan-kaylor-2016


THE ANXIETY AND WITHDRAWAL
THAT TEACHERS CALL QUIET.

The thing we tell ourselves paddling is for

In schools specifically

In 2022 a team did the same work for school corporal punishment alone. Across twenty-one studies and more than sixty-seven thousand children, school paddling went with more acting out, and with more of the anxiety and withdrawal that teachers call quiet and later call depression.

Across twenty studies and nearly a million children, it went with lower school performance. A child who settles down and learns is the thing paddling is associated with less of.

Facts registry: study-visser-2022-school-meta-analysis

WHATSOEVER A MAN SOWETH,
THAT SHALL HE ALSO REAP.

Lest they be discouraged

Colossians 3:21; Galatians 6:7

In 2019 researchers found more than eight hundred young adults from the nineteen states where school paddling was then legal, and matched the ones who had been paddled with the ones who had not. The paddled ones had lower high school grades and more depressive symptoms, and were more likely to say they intended to spank their own children.

Discouraged is the word the King James chose for a child who is provoked, and the researchers, who were not reading Colossians, found it in the data two thousand years later. Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap.

Facts registry: study-gershoff-sattler-holden-2019

PROVE, IN THE OLD SENSE: TEST.

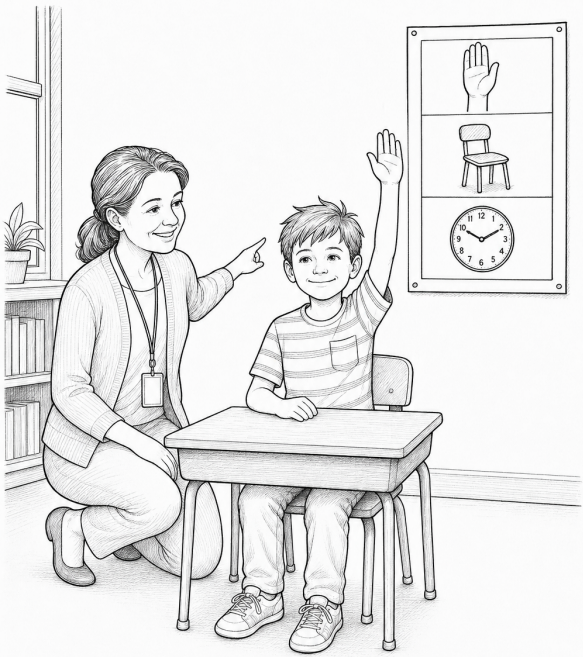
Prove all things; hold fast that which is good

1 Thessalonians 5:21

No study has found that ending corporal punishment increases misbehavior. No study has found that using it improves behavior. The American Academy of Pediatrics, calling in 2023 for the paddle to be abolished in every school in every state, argues from exactly that.

Prove, in the old sense: test. Reading the researchers' report is not doubting the Bible. It is doing what the Bible tells us to do with every practice we inherited, including the ones our grandparents were sure of.

Facts registry: evidence-no-post-ban-outcome-study; org-aap-2023-school-statement



EARLY, OFTEN, AND BEFORE THE THING HAS GONE WRONG.

Chasteneth him betimes

Early, often, and before the thing has gone wrong

The replacement for the paddle is not nothing. It is the teacher's work: teach the expectation first, give a consequence the child can trace to what he did, and practice, because self-control is a skill. Any Sunday school teacher knows this. You have never paddled a child in your classroom, and the room has not fallen apart.

Fifty-four controlled studies of classroom management programs found the students in them did better academically, behaviorally and socially. In a five-year randomized trial across thirty-seven Maryland elementary schools, a child was a third less likely to be sent to the office at all. No controlled study of benefit stands on the other side.

Facts registry: alt-classroom-management-korpershoek-2016; alt-pbis-bradshaw-rcts; evidence-no-post-ban-outcome-study

THREE HUNDRED THIRTY-FOUR TO THREE HUNDRED SIX.

Same scripture. Different board.

What the churches have said

The Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.) adopted a Resolution Against Corporal Punishment in 2012, by three hundred thirty-four votes to three hundred six, and called on every state to prohibit it in schools. The United Methodist Church's 2004 General Conference urged its members to adopt discipline methods that do not include corporal punishment, and in 2024 the church's bishop for Oklahoma wrote that his church does not condone it. The Evangelical Lutheran Church in America's 2025 message on child protection names physical discipline as prohibited in its worshiping communities. The Catholic dioceses I checked prohibit it in their own schools.

The Southern Baptist Convention, the Episcopal Church, the Disciples of Christ and the Church of the Brethren have no position. Silence is not endorsement. It means the question has not come to the floor.

Facts registry: org-pcusa-2012-resolution-against-corporal-punishment; org-umc-2004-discipline-children-without-corporal-punishment; org-umc-oklahoma-bishop-2024-column; org-elca-2025-child-protection-social-message; org-catholic-diocese-des-moines-policy-466; org-catholic-archdiocese-baltimore-discipline-policy; org-denominations-no-position-corporal-punishment-2026-10

MOVE THE SENTENCE.

The Board prohibits the use of corporal punishment in the District.

For the believer on a school board

That is the whole policy, one sentence, and more than eleven hundred school boards in the seventeen permitting states have already adopted it. They are your neighbors, in Alabama and Arkansas and Georgia and Texas and Tennessee and Missouri and Oklahoma.

Before the vote, ask the superintendent in writing for the counts by school, grade, race, sex and disability. In the 2021-22 federal count, boys were about half of enrollment and four fifths of the children struck; Black children were fifteen of every hundred enrolled and twenty-six of every hundred struck. Move the sentence. Set the effective date ninety days out so the training happens first. And if the vote is close, remember that the Presbyterian vote was close too, and the church is still standing.

Facts registry: districts-prohibiting-boards-17-states-2026-10; law-states-permitting-count; crdc-boys-share-2021-22; crdc-black-students-share-2021-22; org-pcusa-2012-resolution-against-corporal-punishment

A page to read aloud

I was a minister. I have spent fifteen years on the question of whether a school should paddle a child, and I want to give you the whole of what I have learned in the time it takes to read this page.

The Bible speaks of the rod. It says a father who loves his son corrects him. I am not here to tell you those verses mean something else. I am here to tell you what the same Bible says about how to judge any correction.

It says: "Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness." Judge the chastening by its fruit, afterward, in the child.

It says: "Ye shall know them by their fruits."

It says: "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good."

So we looked at the fruit. Researchers followed tens of thousands of children, in seventy-five studies, and compared the ones who were hit with the ones who were not. Of seventeen things they measured, thirteen were worse for the children who were hit. Not one was better. In the schools, the children who were paddled did worse in class, not better. They grew up with more depression, and Paul wrote, "Provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged." They

grew up more likely to paddle their own children, and Paul wrote, "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap."

No study has ever found that stopping made a school worse. Fifty-four controlled studies have found that teaching children how to behave, and practicing it with them, makes a school better.

That is the fruit. By scripture's own test, the paddle fails.

Every rod verse in Proverbs is addressed to a parent about that parent's own child. Not one is addressed to a school. The question before a school board is whether an employee of the district may strike someone else's child with a board. Proverbs does not answer that. The fruit does.

The Presbyterians voted on this and said no. The Methodists said no. More than eleven hundred school boards in the states that still allow it have said no, in one sentence: the Board prohibits the use of corporal punishment in the District.

Discipline means teaching. A disciple is a learner. Let us teach them.

Facts registry: study-gershoff-grogan-kaylor-2016;
study-visser-2022-school-meta-analysis; study-gershoff-sattler-holden-2019;
evidence-no-post-ban-outcome-study; alt-classroom-management-korpershoek-2016;
org-pcusa-2012-resolution-against-corporal-punishment;
org-umc-2004-discipline-children-without-corporal-punishment;
districts-prohibiting-boards-17-states-2026-10

Passages cited, in order

- Matthew 28:19-20, "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations"
- Ephesians 6:4, "provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord"
- Hebrews 12:11, "afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness"
- Proverbs 22:6, "Train up a child in the way he should go"
- Proverbs 13:24, "he that loveth him chasteneth him betimes"
- Proverbs 22:15, "the rod of correction shall drive it far from him"
- Proverbs 23:13-14, "Withhold not correction from the child"
- Proverbs 29:15, "The rod and reproof give wisdom"
- Proverbs 19:18, "Chasten thy son while there is hope"
- Matthew 7:16-17, "Ye shall know them by their fruits"
- Colossians 3:21, "provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged"
- Galatians 6:7, "whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap"
- 1 Thessalonians 5:21, "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good"

All quotations are from the King James Version, which is in the public domain, and each was checked against the text. The studies and church positions named at the foot of each page are verified claims in the Safe Schools facts registry at earthpilot.org/kids/resources/, each with its primary source.

The model policy, the motion and the ninety-day transition are in the Safe Discipline Program kit, free at earthpilot.org/kids/kit/.